



## Down in the DUMPS

Political squabbles at the top translate into a rotting away of the grassroots. Uttar Pradesh epitomises the mismanagement.

**T**he stagnation at the top in India's sports bodies has translated into rot all the way down the system. Uttar Pradesh, the state that has produced hockey Olympians like Dhyan Chand and K.D. Singh Babu, badminton stars like Syed Modi, shooters like Jaspal Rana and top flight cricketers like Mohammed Kaif, Suresh Raina and Rudra Pratap Singh, is an apt example of this negative feedback. Look at Lucknow's Guru Gobind Singh Sports College: It's low on funds, has poor infrastructure and paltry manpower with no administrative head to manage its day-to-day affairs for the last four months. The absence of an administrative head has led to anarchy in the college. The staff is on the warpath, demanding a salary hike. The worst

sufferers, however, are the students. Without a sanctioning authority, no kit or equipment is available. The hostels are slum-like and the athletes make do without a mess.

A 19-year-old girl from Basti who plays football tells one of the most shocking stories of Indian sports. "Most aspiring athletes are compelled to work as servants at the residences of sports associations' officials to make their way into the teams," she says.

In another country, the state sports associations would be disbanded, but in Uttar Pradesh, the associations have disbanded their sport. Other than three, (cricket, table tennis and bad-

or a regional sports office. Etawah, Sonbhadra and Siddharth Nagar do not have even a single groundsman for maintenance of the ground and attending to the players, which has reduced the stadia there to grazing grounds for cattle. There is not a single proper shooting range in the state.

In the absence of professional associations, latest infrastructure and well-trained staff, all sports activities have shrunk to a negligible minimum. "In the last four years, no national hockey league has been held in the state. If we do not participate in such tournaments, we would not be able to apply for a job," says a hockey player.



minton) in a list of 24 recognised state sports associations, most have stopped organising district- and state-level league matches. For example, no state football league has been organised for eight years and the chief executive of the football association, an autocrat called Mohammed Shamsuddin, is said to hold players at ransom. One of the most anguished of coaches, Dharendra Singh Chauhan, of the Sunrise Football Club and a functionary of the newly-formed Super Sports Society in Lucknow, blames the state for allowing associations to operate like gangs.

Lucknow is just one cesspool; the lack of a state sports policy is reflected in every district. For 71 districts, there are only 50 stadiums and most of the places don't even have a sports officer

So is the case with football. The football association is hardly doing anything to promote the game at the district and village levels. It just organises district-level leagues and washes its hands off the responsibility of the promotion of the game. The poor representation of the most populated state in the forthcoming Commonwealth Games explains it further.

The state is also way behind in terms of professional manpower. There is an acute shortage of professional coaches. The state's 29 swimming pools have only three coaches while mass sports like hockey have three, and athletics has five. The entire sports department should have more than 1,000 professional coaches, but there are less than 50. "There are coaches who are